



POKER LOGIC LAB

FREE PREVIEW • TWO FULL CHAPTERS

Playing Online Texas Hold'em

The Best Tips for Playing and Winning

Stop losing to better math.

Start winning with better reads.

• POT ODDS & OUTS • PLAYING THE FLOP



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A FREE TWO-CHAPTER PREVIEW

Playing Online Texas Hold 'Em

The Best Tips for Playing and Winning

You are about to read two full chapters from the complete guide, exactly as they appear in the book. No fluff, no watered-down preview.

Pot Odds and Outs is the math that quietly decides who wins and who slowly pays off the table. Playing the Flop is where most hands are truly won and lost. Together they are the heart of solid, winning poker.

As you read, watch for the boxes labeled AT THE LAB. Each one points to a hands-on drill inside Poker Logic Lab where you practice the exact skill the chapter just taught. Reading builds understanding. Drilling builds reflexes.

If these two chapters sharpen your game, the full guide has 19. Get the complete book with lifetime access at pokerlogiclab.com.

Pot Odds and “Outs”

Probability and odds are huge factors in Texas hold 'em. Players use odds to determine their actions. The chances of finishing a flush or a straight, the probability of getting an over card, the percentage of times you're going to flop a set to match your pocket pair are all important factors in poker. Knowledge of these statistics is a key to winning. In online games especially with very few (if any) tells, statistical knowledge becomes the main factor when choosing whether to bet, call, or fold.

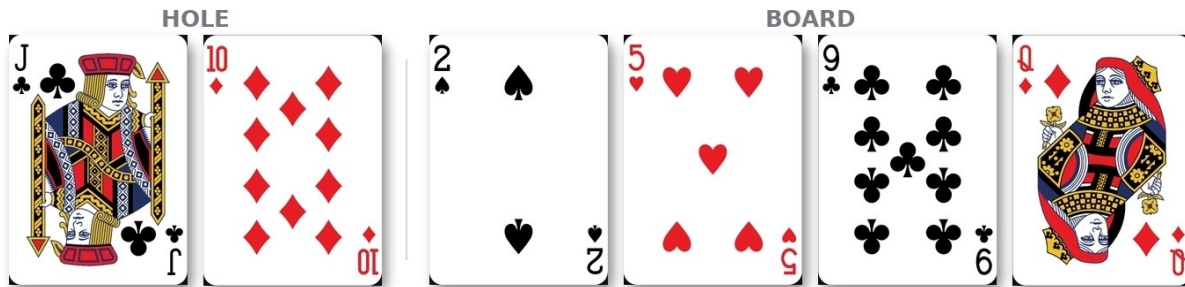
The pot odds decision is one of poker's most elementary, yet it is also one of the most common mistakes made by amateur players at all levels. You will most likely always find a player who is making bad pot odd decisions or ignoring them entirely, meanwhile paying off the rest of the table!

In Texas Hold 'Em, you commonly use outs and pot odds the most. This is also the starting point for those who want to learn about poker odds. To those out there who "ain't good at countin' much", you better get good because that is how it's done. Outs are defined as a card in the deck that helps you make your hand. At this point it's only simple division.

The numerator (top number) will be the number of outs you have. The denominator (bottom number) is the number of cards left that we haven't seen. The result will be the percentage chance of making one of those outs. Therefore, the most math you'll be doing will be dividing small numbers by 50 (pre-flop), 47 (after the flop), or 46 (after the turn)

Pot odds are as easy as computing outs. You compare your outs or your chance of winning to the size of the pot. If your chance of winning is significantly better than the ratio of the pot size to a bet, then you have good pot odds. If it's lower, then you have bad pot odds.

For example, say you are in a \$5/\$10 hold em game with Jack-Ten facing one opponent on the turn. You have an outside straight draw with a board of 2-5-9-Q, and only the river card left to make it. Any 8 or any King will finish this straight for you, so you have 8 outs (four 8's and 4 K's left in the deck) and 46 unseen cards left. $8/46$ is almost the same as a 1 in 6 chance of making it. Your sole opponent bets \$10. If you take a \$10 bet you could win \$200. $\$200/\10 is 20, so you stand to make 20x more if you call. $1/6$ is higher than $1/20$, so pot odds say that calling wouldn't be a bad idea.



Open-ended straight draw: any 8 or King completes it.

The next step is to use bet odds and implied odds. That's tougher, because it involves predicting reactions of other players. With bet odds, you try to factor in how many people are going to call a raise. With implied odds, you're thinking about reactions for the rest of the game. One last example on implied odds...

Say it's another \$5/\$10 hold em game and you have a four flush on the flop. Your neighbor bets, and everyone else folds. The pot is \$50 at this point. First you figure out your chance of hitting your flush on the turn, and it comes out to about 19.1% (about 1 in 5). You have to call this \$5 bet versus a \$50 pot, so that's a 10x payout. 1/5 is higher than 1/10, so bet odds are okay, but you must consider that this guy's going to bet into you on the turn and river also. That's the \$5 plus two more \$10 bets. So now you're facing \$25 more till the end of the hand.

You have to consider your chances of hitting that flush on the turn or river, which makes it about 35% (better than 1 in 3 now), but you have to invest \$25 for a finishing pot of \$100. That's 4-to-1 on your money for a draw that comes in better than one time in three, so the call is clearly profitable over the long run. But there's more! If you don't make it on the turn, it'll change your outs and odds! You'll have a 19.6% chance of hitting the flush (little worse than 1 in 5), but a \$20 investment for a finishing pot of \$100! \$100/\$20 is 1 in 5. So the chances would take a nasty turn if you didn't hit it! What makes it more complicated is that if you did hit it on the turn, you could raise him back, and get an extra \$20 or maybe even \$40 in the pot. The bottom line: with a bare flush draw you can usually afford to call a single bet, but be cautious about paying big bets on both the turn and the river to chase it.

Is there an easier way to calculate pot odds? Thankfully, there are several short cuts that have been devised to make a quick judgment for pot odds.

One of the easiest methods is to take your total outs, multiply by 2, and then add 2. This is roughly a percentage chance of making your hand.

For example, say you have an inside straight draw with 4 outs. $4 \times 2 = 8$. Add 2, for a total of 10. You have roughly a 10% chance to make your hand. Your call should be no more than 10% of what is already in the pot. This method is quick and decently effective, though certain calculations will be a bit off. This method does not take into consideration the fact that you may have more than one card

remaining to come; it simply estimates your chance of hitting your "out" on your next card.

There are a number of tools online that help you calculate your odds. Just do a Google search, and you'll find several. Keep in mind, though, that using them may significantly slow your play and cause your fellow players to interpret this as a "tell".

There is a better fix than reaching for a calculator: make the math automatic. A few minutes of pot-odds and EV reps, done away from the table, is enough to turn counting outs into something you run in your head in real time, with no tell and no delay.

Playing your pocket cards is key, but you'll also need to know some strategies when it comes to the flop and the river.

AT THE LAB

Counting outs and comparing them to the pot is the single most valuable habit in this whole book, and it is pure repetition. Drill it until it runs in your head.

Mental Math Blitz: 30-second pot-odds and EV sprints that build fast, table-ready math so you can count outs and price a call in seconds, no calculator required.

Equity Calculator: drop in your hand, the board, and a range for your opponent, and get the straight 'is the price right?' answer: the exact question the outside-straight and flush-draw examples above are asking.

The book itself warns that leaning on an online odds calculator mid-hand slows your play and becomes a tell. The point of drilling is to make the math automatic so you never need one at the table.

Playing the Flop

Besides the dealing of the pocket cards, and your decision to fold or hold them, the Flop is probably the most important moment in Texas Hold em. Three cards hit the board, often making "nut" hands out of weak pocket cards, and at times, making strong pocket cards useless. Your ability to read the flop will be a huge factor in your success in Texas Hold em.

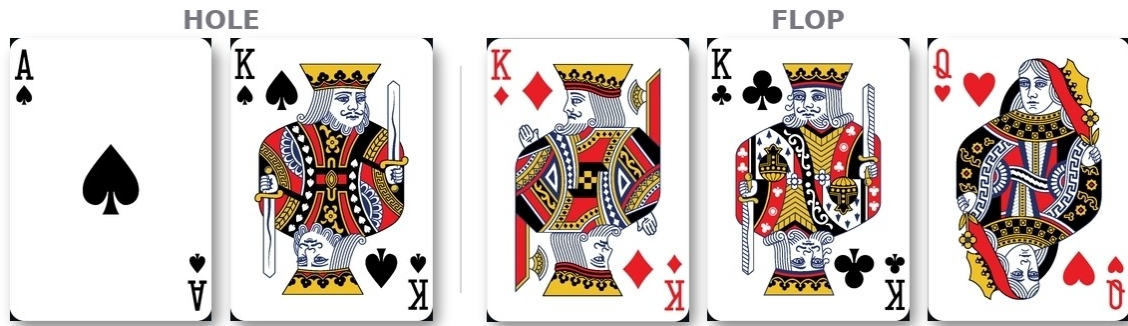
Flopping 3 of a Kind

There is a difference between flopping a set and flopping trips. First, flopping a set would be a situation where you hold a strong pair, such as KK, and the flop comes K-A-6. Your monster 3 Kings are hidden, and anyone with an Ace is probably going to be putting in a raise, seeing top pair on the flop. The potential for this hand is amazing, and slow play would be a good option.



Flopping a set: pocket kings, and a third king lands on a K-A-6 flop.

A similar situation we will call flopping trips. This would be a situation where you hold only one of the 3 cards as your pocket card. Say you hold AK suited, and the flop comes out K-K-Q. Here again, you have 3 of a kind, but even so, you have to understand that this is a bit of a weaker hand. Anytime a pair is showing on board, there is danger of a full house already formed. QQ would definitely be a hand that someone would hold onto, and if given this flop, your 3 Kings are losers. It's also harder to maximize a pot with the two Kings on the flop. Those are huge scare cards, and if you bet out right away, you may get nothing more than what is already in the pot. Again, slow play, and be especially careful of an already formed full house.



Flopping trips: A-K meets a paired K-K-Q board (weaker than a set).

There are, however, certain times you want to jam the pot with 3 of a kind. If the flop gives chances for a straight draw, like K-K-10, where anyone holding Q-J has a good chance at a straight, or if 2 of the cards are the same suit, giving someone a chance at a flush if they held onto a pair of same suited cards. In these instances, they are going to play to the river, so make them pay to see extra cards!

Another time you want to jam the pot is if you have flopped a small set. For example you checked with the big blind with a pair of 3's, and the flop comes out Q-8-3. You have your set, and will most likely win with it, but you don't want to risk someone holding a higher pair getting their set on the turn or river for free. Bet, raise, check raise if you know someone else will bet, whatever you have to do to narrow down your competition and hopefully force out the medium pairs. What you like to see is someone with AQ in this situation with top pair, top kicker who will give you action but has very little chance of winning it. Jam the pot with small sets.

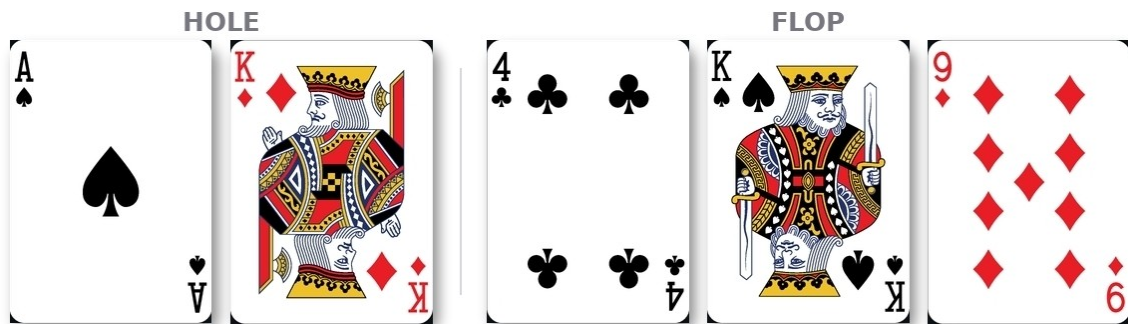


Flopping a small set: pocket threes on a Q-8-3 flop.

Top Pair after the Flop

If you held a high pair before the flop and were jamming the pot, then you should continue to jam the pot if you still hold the top pair. If you held Q-Q, and the flop comes out 10-2-7, you have an overpair and are most likely still the leader, unless someone was slow playing Aces or Kings before the flop, or someone with 10's just flopped a set. The fact is, if you play aggressively with a high pair before the flop, you will generally know whether or not you still have the lead.

If you held A-K, and the flop comes out 4-K-9, here again, you're jamming the pot. You hold top pair with the best kicker, and the last thing you want is for someone to draw out and complete a flush or straight to beat you.



Top pair, top kicker: A-K on a K-9-4 flop.

Top pair is strong after the flop, but definitely not strong enough to sit on and slow play.

Flopping a small Pair

Suppose you were holding A-8 of clubs, and the flop comes out Q-8-3. You have missed your flush draw, because only the 3 is clubs, but you have flopped a pair of "babies." You have to respect the fact that someone may have a queen, and have you beat. Even so, if the action is checked to you, you should seriously consider putting in a bet here. By putting in the bet, you accomplish the purpose of finding out the true strength of your pair. If anyone holds a queen, you can expect a raise. If you have the high hand, expect calls. If you are raised, then you must consider the personality of who raised you. If a weak or tough player raises you then it might be time to call or fold. If it's the mediocre player, then by all means stay in, and even re-raise.

This particular hand might be hard to fold, though, simply because you still have a lot of outs. An ace would give you a huge hand; another 8 would be even better, and there's always the possibility of 2 more clubs hitting the board.

So, go ahead and bet with the small pairs, and then judge by your opponent's personalities and actions as to where you stand.

Flopping a Monster Hand

By monster hand, we mean flopping a royal flush, 4 of a kind, full house, flush, straight, and straight flush. Statistically the hand is yours or practically yours. In most circumstances, the best choice is to slow play. You want the other players to stay in and build a decent hand that they will bet with or at least call to the river with.

We offer a word of caution though. In the case of flushes and straights, make sure you don't get caught with the low end of a straight or a low card flush, where

someone makes the same straight with a higher card, or someone makes the same flush with a higher card. If you are playing good quality pocket cards though, this should rarely happen. But if your flush is only a 10 high, bet aggressively and try to force out anyone holding a jack, queen, king or ace of your suit. Granted, most people won't fold with four to a flush, but at least you're making them pay for a chance to get their card.

As a general rule then, slow play the monsters and wait till the more expensive turn and river to begin extracting chips from your opponents.

Flopping a Flush or Straight Draw

You have to first of all understand that odds are still against you making your hand (2-1 with four to a flush or open ended straight). But the rule of thumb to follow here is that Texas Hold em rewards aggressive play. Bet this hand if it is checked to you and hope for one of two results. Either everyone else folds and you pick up a small pot, or you end up making your flush or straight and winning a huge one.

If there are bets and raises to you, then you will need to resort to calculating pot odds to determine if it is profitable to call or in some cases raise.

Flopping 2 Pair

Say you hold J-10 suited, and the flop comes out 10-4-J. You have managed to flop the top two pair. I would tend to jam the pot with two pair. While two pair is strong, there are still a lot of hands that can beat it. There is no harm in jamming the pot and elbowing everyone else off the table. If you end up making a full house on the later streets, you can adjust your strategy, but for the moment, you want to bet and force the limpers out.



Flopping top two pair: J-10 on a 10-4-J flop.

There are exceptions to this of course. If you hold AQ and the flop comes out AQ2 rainbow, you are pretty strong and can afford to let someone catch up a little. Read the texture of the flop. If the flop is suited or connected you definitely do not want to mess around with slow playing, but rather get your chips in while you are ahead and charge the draw hands to play. Flops that show little help to the other players

might be worth slow playing a bit so that they improve enough to call your bets on the turn and river or give an aggressive player a chance to bluff.

Ugly Flops

If you are holding onto a marginal type hand, and it is not helped at all by the flop, then plan on checking and folding. Taking bad hands to the river will take a major toll on your bankroll.

The turn or 4th Street in Hold em is the first instance where the bets are doubled. You can hear the "cha-ching" in your ears, as you bet those good hands. However, for the beginner, this street can be exceptionally dangerous, as this is where many players complete their straights and flushes, along with all of the other hand possibilities of poker.

If you have played good poker up to this point, at both the pocket card selection and flop, then you should have some idea of whether or not you are ahead or behind in the hand. As a general rule, if you are ahead after seeing this 4th card hit the board then bet and start building the pot. On the other hand, if you are pretty sure you are behind, this is the prime time to fold your hand, before you start throwing your money away by calling the expensive bets.

Say you were dealt J-J, and you bet aggressively before and after the flop. The flop and turn board looks like this: Q-3-7-A, three of which are diamonds, and unfortunately, you hold the black jacks (spades and clubs). You should fold this hand to any raises. Why? Count how many ways you are beat: an ace, queen, 2 diamonds, or 1 diamond if another shows on the river, plus a remote straight opportunity if the river card is a 10, K or another Jack. That's a lot of ways to beat you.

Now count how many "outs" you have and what the best possible hand is that you could form. Right now, your best hope is another Jack, giving you three of a kind. Are you willing to call bets and raises when there are only two cards left in the deck that can help you, and even then, still have a shot at getting beat by someone blessed with a diamond flush or straight??

Good poker play before and after the flop gives you the information you need to make the decision on the Turn. Stick with your gut instinct. If you're ahead, bet, and if you're behind, fold unless you are getting good pot odds with a draw hand. Don't pray for miracle cards. Play the cards you hold.

Now that you have the flop, the turn will come, but perhaps the most significant card you want to see is the river.

AT THE LAB

Reading the flop (flop set vs. flopped trips, top pair, ugly flop) is where hands are won and lost. It rewards seeing hundreds of them.

Hand Replay: the flop hits, the hand pauses, and you choose your line; you find out immediately whether to jam, slow-play, or fold, and why.

Equity Calculator: test any flop texture (paired boards, two-tone, connected) to see how your holding really stands against the range that would call you.

That was two chapters. There are seventeen more.

You just saw how this book teaches: real hands, the plain-English why, and a drill for every idea. The complete guide keeps going, through position, betting, tells, bluffing, tournaments, sit and go's, limit games, and the mindset that separates winners from everyone else.

And it is built to be practiced, not just read. Every AT THE LAB box points to a drill in Poker Logic Lab, where the math becomes automatic and the reads become second nature.

The full guide comes free with the app.
Start training at pokerlogiclab.com